1.1 Early American Civilizations

The Americas were never a blank slate, waiting for someone to "discover" them. People began arriving in the region about 20,000 years ago. Over time, they developed cultures that would influence all of the Americas and the world.

MAIN IDEA Civilizations emerged and thrived in Mesoamerica and South America for thousands of years.

MESOAMERICA

Long before 1492, great **civilizations**, or complex societies, arose in the Americas. The earliest of these civilizations began in **Mesoamerica**, which stretches from southern Mexico into part of Central America. Mesoamerica's landscape consists of two main areas: highlands and lowlands. The highlands lie between the mountains of the Sierra Madre (see-AIR-uh MAH-dray), a mountain system in Mexico. The lowlands are found along the coast of the Gulf of Mexico and in the jungles of the Yucatán (yoo-kuh-TAN) Peninsula. Both areas provided fertile land for agriculture.

The fertile land allowed several civilizations to develop in Mesoamerica. The **Olmec**, **Maya**, and **Aztec** thrived at different times from around 1200 B.C. to about A.D. 1520. The oldest civilization, the Olmec society, settled along present-day Mexico's Gulf Coast. The Maya, who were influenced by Olmec culture, mainly lived in parts of the countries we now call Mexico, Guatemala, and Belize. The Aztec were the last of the major Mesoamerican civilizations, establishing their empire in central and southern Mexico.

SOUTH AMERICA

To the south of Mesoamerica lies South America, a continent twice the size of the United States. South America contains coastal plains, dry forests and deserts, and vast river basins covered by dense rain forests and grasslands. The Andes Mountains rise along the continent over a distance of about 5,500 miles, extending from the northwestern coast all the way down to the southern tip. The mountains divide the Pacific coast from the continent's interior and separated the early civilizations in lands that are now the countries of Peru, Bolivia, Argentina, and Chile.

The **Moche** (MOH-chay) and the **Inca** were two of the most important early civilizations. The Moche lived on the arid northern coast of present-day Peru between about A.D. 100 and 800. They developed a complex **irrigation** system that channeled water to their crops. The rise of the Inca started in the 12th century. They established a capital city in Cusco (KOOS-koh), Peru, and later built the complex and mysterious city of Machu Picchu (MAH-choo PEE-choo) high in the Andes Mountains.



Moche Metalworking The Moche were known for their vibrant murals, fine pottery, and advanced metalwork. Gold monkey-head beads, like this one, were often buried with members of the Moche nobility.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Which three civilizations developed in Mesoamerica?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the highlands and lowlands of Mesoamerica similar?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** How do you think the Andes Mountains benefited both the Moche and the Inca?

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OLMEC 1200–400 B.C.

- Carved colossal rock heads thought to represent Olmec rulers
- Established an extensive trade network that carried Olmec goods and culture throughout Mesoamerica

MOCHE A.D. 100–800

- Left no written record, so all we know of their culture is through their artwork
- Built pyramid-like structures at their capital, called Moche, one of which was almost 165 feet tall

MAYA A.D. 250–900

- Developed a hieroglyphic writing system and created a calendar
- Established more than 40 cities throughout Mesoamerica

INCA A.D. 1100–1535

- Built a vast empire that extended from the northern border of Ecuador to central Chile
- Constructed a system of roads, bridges, and cities, such as Machu Picchu

AZTEC A.D. 1200–1520

- Built an empire of up to six million people
- Required children to attend public schools

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